



ARTS ILLUSTRATED



Editor's note

While working on this issue, and now on this edit note, it comes to me slowly, like a ball rolling to a stop at my feet, that this word 'reverse' is a clever little word. It asks you to do two things – one is to go back in time (walk with forward steps or backward steps, your choice, it tells you generously), and the other is to re-look or maybe re-do whatever was done before, but with a dramatic shift in perspective, and a hyper awareness of time and space. In our otherwise very linear lives, reverse is like the walls you hit in a maze, making you change direction till you find the next opening, and the next, and the next, till you realise your steps are moving to an altogether different rhythm. Like I said, clever.

Initially, we tried to ride this unpredictable wave with what we thought was us being clever – consciously reversing our interpretations, trying hard to break linear structures and sequencing, thinking of ideas too big for their own boots – and then quickly gave up. The only way was a reversal of our roles – we had to submit, meekly, to its many whims and fancies and trust in that process.

Our stories, therefore, have marched to entirely differing tunes, swirling and twirling around dots we see every day and yet drawing completely new patterns each time. This issue was a breathless experience of being mere spectators, watching and observing and marvelling, and knowing through it all that without this boundary of an audience, the stage would become non-existent. I suspect that the thing called reverse, being clever and all, knows it too.



Praveena Shivram
praveena@artsillustrated.in

Cover Artist



My paintings are like a memoir. I reference stories from the ones I heard as a child, the games we played to my life in a rural setting (I was born in Sanjaya, a small village in Gujarat). Inspiration from folk and tribal traditions can also be seen in my renditioning. Motifs, symbols and an overall sensibility of design, like borders to my frames, emerge from the decorations of a typical courtyard in a village home or handmade textiles.

I began exploring painting in reverse on a glass sheet in 2006. I saw works of KG Subramanyan and Nalini Malani. I was very curious to try it for myself. Soon I realised that it was very different from painting on paper or canvas. On paper, the paint gets absorbed and adheres quickly. In contrast, on a glass surface it remains wet and catches every stroke of the brush. Plus, one had to think in reverse

too. What I paint first will be most visible on the other side, unlike painting on canvas, where the first layer becomes the background and what I paint on it shows as the final image.

For the cover of this issue of Arts Illustrated, I used the reverse technique to paint a work titled 'The Magician'. Various elements emerge from his headgear and he appears entertaining and amusing. As a child, I never missed the opportunity to see the *Ram-Lila* performances. The over-the-top costumes they wore were fascinating. Every evening we used to wait for snake charmers and monkey trainers, and would run after the *beheroopiyas* (impersonators). Those vivid memories never leave my mind and I continue to draw my inspiration from them.



Madhvi Parekh

Cover design curated by Rahul Kumar.



Still from the film Mahanati (2018) by Nag Ashwin.



Cinema Q & A

Yesterday Once More

The making of a biopic lends itself to many readings, many layers, each unearthed in retrospect – for the maker as much as for the viewer

SARITHA RAO RAYACHOTI

My mother held my little brother in one hand and clasped my hand in the other. She walked determinedly through the backyard among its many mango trees casting moon-dappled shadows. Reaching the gate at the rear, we collected the tickets from the elderly watchman, whom we simply called Thatha. We stepped on to the street and walked into the movie theatre that was so close next door, that we could sometimes hear in our kitchen the more beat-intensive songs, and the fight sequences from the climax. I could barely quell the excitement pulsing through me. We would stay up late like grown-ups! We would watch a night show like them! And we would watch a 'grown-up' movie with complex family conflicts, not silly cartoons with talking animals or obedient, well-behaved children.

This was Madurai of the 1980s, but the Tamil movies we went to watch in that theatre that year were reruns of the ones that were released in the 1960s. The family dramas we watched are like a memory quilt for me. Here was *Paasa Malar*, where a brother and sister, who dote on each other, are separated by scheming family members and petty misunderstandings. Here was *Paava Mannippu*, the tale of the rich zamindar who disfigures an adversary with acid, not realising that he is his long lost son. Here was *Padithaal Mattum Podhumaa* where a man's act of deception to marry the woman he loves also ends up sabotaging his brother's life.

We watched many movies from this series that began with the syllable 'pa', usually starring Sivaji Ganesan as the leading man. But then we were also enamoured by Savitri, whose on-screen presence was a combination of winsome and affectionate, but in the face of conflict always displayed traditional Indian virtues like patience, empathy, fierce loyalty and duty consciousness. It wasn't until recently that I read about the special place that cinema held among women in Madurai of a particular era. They would throng the theatres on weekend mornings with kids in tow, carrying with them all manner of refreshments, making a social gathering out of a movie show. And it wasn't until I watched Nag Ashwin's *Mahanati* (Telugu), a biopic on the life of the actress Savitri Ganesan, that I realised how much of a contribution her on-screen presence (and the curiosity about her off-screen life) may have played in drawing women out of their domestic preoccupations and into the theatres.

I wonder if that's what emboldened my mother to not let a significant detail like the lack of company come in the way of watching a movie. Viewed through today's feminist lens, it may not seem like much of a statement, but it was an act of assertion for her to watch a night show when the man of the house was out of town, even if that movie was in the theatre next door.

In May this year, I watched *Mahanati* with my mother and brother, but this time, our father joined us. As Savitri's (played by Keerthy Suresh) story unfolded on screen, we admired her pluck, her acting talent, her abiding love for Gemini Ganesan (Dulquer Salman) and her confidence in directing a movie with an all-woman crew. We empathised with the isolation of the 'other woman', and we saw the beginning of her decline when she turns to alcohol to nurse a broken heart.

In addition to the costumes and the art direction that went into visually recreating a bygone era for the biopic, I was awestruck by the work of *Mahanati*'s cinematographer Dani Sanchez-Lopez who not only recreated Savitri's more famous on-screen moments in black and white, but also captured the splendour of the studio era in colour, and employed visual metaphors to subliminally foretell the unfolding story. I was transported right back to that darkened movie theatre where the screen dominated our attention, and collective gasps, the smell of popcorn and the babble of children accompanied by their movie-crazy parents, all added to the experience.

Over an e-mail interview, Dani answered my questions about this retrospective experience of *Mahanati* that both of us seemed to have embarked on, albeit in entirely different ways.

Excerpts from the interview:

While it is one thing to approach a film purely from a cinematographer's perspective, it is quite another for the cinematographer to react to the film as a viewer. How did you balance the two, given your vast technical experience and your completely fresh outlook to Savitri's era of cinema?

I have always been an avid film watcher. Since I was a kid, my favourite thing would be watching movies with my parents or my aunt and uncle. As teenagers, people usually learn to play music, sports, dance... I watched five movies a day. Like studying a language, or painting, one learns so much from analysing films. Especially classics that have survived the oblivion of time. And the more you learn the deeper you are able to see into them. I still have a vast pool of Tamil-Telugu classics to watch, but I learnt a great deal from the ones I watched, and they helped me shape the visual design of *Mahanati*.

How did the visual identity of the movie evolve from Nag Ashwin's initial brief to you?

For Nagi, less is more. Like a skyscraper by Mies Van Der Rohe, you have to dig into its structure to understand what brilliant ideas its reflective façade hides beneath. He gave me some macro-concepts in our first brief – vintage, epic and the colour palette. Nagi had seen my work in *San'75* and had been captivated by how we gave that sense of

the 1970s without resorting to tinting, or simply emulating the style of films from that era. And the colour palette brought the feeling of a photograph from that time, but perceived now, with the squalor time inflicts. *Mahanati* needed that and more, since her story started in the 1940s and tragically ended in the 1980s. We were very aware of the evolution of film and cinematography to our contemporary times, and we wanted a very dynamic camera that would integrate with the edit even on set. Nagi rarely asks for coverage, so we had to plan in detail how the edit will flow and maximise our dollies.

I am reminded of Alwin H. Küchler's work for Danny Boyle's movie Steve Jobs (2015) and three visually distinct sequences from the life of Steve Jobs shot in three different formats. For Mahanati, the 'present day' in the story is set in the 1980s, and you have used the film format to shoot this sequence. However, the flashback sequences for Savitri's life go as far back as the 1950s and are shot in the digital format. Tell us more about your decision to 'reverse' the formats for the sequences.

Thank you for bringing Alwin Küchler to the table; he is a cinematographer I admire. His work in *Ratcatcher* and





Still from the film **Mahanati** (2018) by Nag Ashwin.



Behind the scenes, Making of **Mahanati**.



Behind the scenes, Making of **Mahanati**.

Morvern Callar with Lynne Ramsay does not cease to intrigue me. There are also very distinct looks for different periods in *The Godfather II* by Gordon Willis, *Casino* by Richardson, or *The Bad Education* by Rodrigo Prieto.

The first conversation with Nagi about visual design was actually about formats. We both started our careers in film and loved the look of 35mm film, the grain structure, the colours, the soft cadence into highlights... No other format has come close to it yet, but the budget did not allow for it. I proposed 16mm then. I was infatuated by the look of Jackie by Stéphane Fontaine or Carol by Ed Lachman. We did some tests and, ironically, locked Super 16mm for the present in the story.

In cinema history there is this wheel that fluctuates from studio shooting with heavy cameras and lights and new waves that allow the camera to move and shoot on location with less

number of lights. Bear in mind, the present in *Mahanati* is the early 1980s. At that time, new faster colour stock was released, and that is how we remember film from that time. The grain was more prominent, the colours tend to ochres, and lighting could become much more realistic. We added handheld to this visual design for a sense of naïveté that Samantha's and Vijay's characters as journalists tracing Savitri's story bring to the screen.

For the flashback, we wanted to pay homage to the grandness of the films Savitri shot. We leaned to the Alexa digital camera, for its dynamic range, colour science and cinematic texture, and Nagi suggested anamorphic lens, which certainly carries that vintage look from its source, with vignette and beautiful aberrations. But her story is so complex that it was not enough. We wanted a progression of looks.

Cinematography should transport the audience to the stage of Savitri's life we were in. We achieved this with the combination of spherical Master Prime lenses and Hawke V-Lite anamorphic lens, a progression of different diffusion filters on camera (we even used Vaseline at some point, which is a trick used mostly in the black and white era) and lights. We go from very organic lighting to the most stylised in her Mahanati era. Using a low F-stop on anamorphic lenses is not advisable, since the lens will reveal all its flaws, such as stark vignetting, softer bands on the top and bottom of the frame, lens aberrations... But at the end of her story we wanted to make you feel the sense of agony she was going through.

How has your perspective on a cinematographer like Marcus Bartley (who worked on movies like Missiamma and Mayabazaar with Savitri)

changed, after you recreated his scenes for Mahanati?

Oh, he was a master! Undeniably! His lighting is very modern compared to that of his contemporaries and he was so precise in the execution of his shot movements. My favourite shot in *Mayabazaar* is the introduction to Savitri in the film at the fountain, because it evidences such cinematic knowledge: a true collaboration between blocking-camera-lighting-editing to create a striking transition.

The thing I inherited from him was how he liked to light Savitri. When Savitri is Mahanati in the film, there are always two light sources twinkling in her eyes. This is rare, as one source was always preferred, more organic and less work from the lighting team. I thought this gave a great subtle epic look, and was a great symbol for the film.



Behind the scenes, Making of **Mahanati**.



Behind the scenes, Making of **Mahanati**.

For the dualism between Mahanati and Savitri. Who she was and who they wanted her to be.

The visual design in the film also works well in moving the depiction of conflicts from external to internal. I want to draw attention to a striking scene where Savitri's personal life gets upturned on the night of the premiere of the movie she directed. This leads to her taking to alcohol to escape from what she regards as betrayals and transgressions. You have used the figurative description of her 'world turning upside down' and shot it literally for this scene. Please tell us about how that scene came to be conceptualised and shot.

You have analysed it beautifully. The premiere night

is an inflexion in Savitri's story. Her ascension takes a volte-face and the fall from grace commences. From the warm spotlight of her premiere, Savitri sneaks out to the darkness that is the guesthouse Gemini is staying at. Lighting becomes very contrasty and the camera suddenly goes handheld and follows her. The most accurate time to value performances is when you cannot edit them. The discovery happens in an uncut sequence shot in which both Keerthy and Dulquer demonstrate their nuanced craft.

This was a difficult scene also for cinematography, since we do a 360-degree handheld shot. We had to light from the windows and use practical lighting on set. It was also a one-take-wonder, since the

actors cannot recreate such an intense scene... A lot of pressure was put on Hari, the focus puller, who had no space to turn with the camera and had to hide lying on the floor.

Once at home, Savitri shatters her own image on the mirror. From wide to close, from high to low, the camera only pauses the moment she sits down on the bed and decides to drink. Nagi wanted something very special for this moment and we racked our brains to find something apt for it. I wanted the camera to climb her, and go around her, until it showed Keerthy's face, completely upside down, the only way to portray it at this point. Nagi added the drinking from the bottle the moment we are on top, and Keerthy fell on the bed right after, leading to two

of the most iconic shots in the film. It was again an impeccable collaboration between direction, lighting, camera movement and acting.

A set of mirrors also plays a larger role in a scene of some visual complexity where both Savitri and Gemini Ganesan sit back-to-back at their respective dressing tables and smile at each other's reflections that reflect to infinity. In some ways, this cues the complexity of their relationship too. Did you plan on that scene being a sort of red herring alerting the audience about the conflicts to come in their marriage?

Exactly! This small cut came to substitute a scene that was erased in which they had their first argument in front of a make-up mirror. It was an amazing scene in which we confused the audience between their image and their reflections and we went through the warm bright of the mirrors to reveal who they really were in the end. But you could also read this scene in the complete opposite manner; Gemini and Savitri complement each other so well that they don't need anyone else. Or they confuse their duality and become one, or they are in love with their own reflection... In a way, in love, there is a lot of the water metaphor, where we see ourselves reflected in the other.

Among the movies of Savitri's that you have watched as part of your research for Mahanati, which specific scene or sequence did you think best captured her essence?



Still from the film **Mahanati** (2018) by Nag Ashwin.

That is a hard one to answer. But as an entire film, I found it very interesting to see how she portrayed being possessed by a male god in *Mayabazaar*, where the male inside her has to pretend to be feminine. I was also interested in this aspect of Savitri: she was very popular not only for being a great actress but also for indulging in activities reserved for men at the time, like smoking, racing cars and drinking. She directed a film

with a whole female crew! That is such a contemporary feminist idea now. I feel like *Mahanati* appeared in my life like a comet, unexpectedly, and demanding my whole attention gazing at its shining light. It has been a very special project and I do not think I will be able to experience another film like this one.

All Images Courtesy of Dani Sanchez-Lopez



